

Great Debates for ESL/EFL

**39 Important Debating Topics
for English Learners**



Jackie Bolen

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www.eslactivity.org

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About the Author: Jackie Bolen

I taught English in South Korea for a decade to every level and type of student, including every age from kindergarten kids to adults. These days, I'm living in Vancouver and teaching English to a variety of students. In my spare time, you can usually find me outside surfing, biking, hiking or on the hunt for the most delicious kimchi I can find.

In case you were wondering what my academic qualifications are, I hold a Master of Arts in Psychology. During my time in Korea, I completed both the Cambridge CELTA and DELTA certification programs. With the combination of years teaching ESL/EFL learners of all ages and levels, and the more formal teaching qualifications I've obtained, I have a solid foundation on which to offer teaching advice. I truly hope that you find this book useful and would love it if you sent me an email with any questions or feedback that you might have—I'll always take the time to respond (jb.business.online@gmail.com).

Jackie Bolen around the Internet

ESL Speaking (www.eslspeaking.org) **YouTube**
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How to Use this Book

These debate topics are designed for teenagers, university students, and adults. They assume a basic knowledge of English grammar and vocabulary so are best suited for intermediate or advanced students.

The main purpose of these lessons is to get students talking about a certain debate topic and can be used for classes of 30 minutes to two hours. There are 39 different debating topics in total and each lesson includes the following:

- an icebreaker question – the big question (debate topic) – 3 common positions that people might take on the topic – 5 vocabulary words with definitions – 10 discussion questions

For smaller classes of less than three students, it's possible to work through each lesson together as a class. It's also possible to use these conversation lessons for 1-1 or private tutoring. However, for larger classes of four or more, I recommend putting students into pairs and letting them work through the lesson together to make classes more student-centered.

Animal Testing

Icebreaker What kinds of products are tested on animals?

The Big Question Should animal testing be illegal?

Position 1

Animal testing should be illegal because it's immoral and cruel. Animals live short, terrible lives in small cages and undergo tests that cause pain and suffering. With advances in technology, animal testing isn't necessary these days. Companies can also use materials they already know are safe in their products, especially for cosmetics.

Position 2

Animal testing shouldn't be illegal because it's necessary for testing things like cosmetics and medicines. Humans are more important than animals like mice, and using them for testing can help us find treatments for things like cancer and other medical conditions.

Position 3

Animals should be used for testing new medications that can save lives. However, they shouldn't be used for less important things like cosmetics.

Vocabulary immoral: Not ethical or moral.

cruel: Mean.

pain and suffering: Physical discomfort and emotional distress.

cosmetics: Make-up, hair and skin care products, etc.

medicines: Something taken to treat or prevent a disease or illness.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you support? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Are some animals more important than others (gorillas vs. mice, for example)?
4. Scientists have just come up with a new treatment that they think will cure cancer, but they need to test it on animals. Do you think they should do that?
5. A company has come up with a new treatment that helps people who are losing their hair due to aging, but they need to test it on animals to ensure that it's safe for humans. Should they do that?
6. Should medications and cosmetics be tested on people instead of animals?
7. Will technology one day eliminate the need for animal testing?
8. Do you know any animal rights groups such as PETA or Sea Shepherd? What do you think about them?
9. Should hurting an animal be a crime?
10. Should governments have laws against animal testing, or is it up to the companies to decide if they want to do it?

Immigration

Icebreaker Have you ever considered immigrating to another country (or maybe you've already done it)? Why or why not?

The Big Question

Should your country welcome more immigrants in the coming year?

Position 1

Yes, my country needs more immigrants. We have an aging population, and immigrants often have big families with lots of children who can help us have a vibrant, healthy society. Overall, they will help my country, especially in the long term.

Position 2

No, my country doesn't need more immigrants. Healthcare, education, and other institutions are already facing challenges due to budget cutbacks and too many people. Housing prices are already so expensive that we don't need more people here. They will take our jobs and hurt poor people.

Position 3

We need some immigrants but only skilled workers such as doctors, nurses, teachers, tradespeople, etc. We should be selective about who we accept. They should be young, well-educated, have money, and be able to get a job and pay taxes right away. Basically, they can come as long as they aren't a burden.

Vocabulary immigrants: People who move to live in another country permanently.

skilled workers: Highly-trained and educated people who perform jobs that not everyone can do.

aging population: The average age of a group of people is increasing due to increased life expectancy and low birth rates.

tradespeople: People who do jobs with their hands like plumbing, welding, fixing cars, etc. They require training and skills to do them well.

vibrant: Alive; healthy.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you agree with a little bit?
3. Do you know any immigrants? Why did they move?
4. List some other reasons why people might immigrate.
5. Do you think that immigrants are treated well in most countries? Why or why not?
6. Should immigrants maintain their culture or assimilate to the new one?
7. Should immigrants be required to learn the local language?
8. Do immigrants affect the economy in a positive or negative way overall?
9. Should illegal immigrants be deported?
10. Should there be restrictions on the kinds of jobs immigrants can do?

Big Brother (Surveillance)

Icebreaker Security cameras are everywhere. Name a few places where you might find them.

The Big Question

Should surveillance cameras be used in public places?

Position 1

Yes, surveillance cameras should be used in all public places. They can be used to look for problems, find criminals, or have a record of who was in a certain place at a certain time for a public health emergency.

Position 2

No, surveillance cameras shouldn't be used in public places. People should have the freedom to go places and do things without being monitored by "big brother." Police should use other methods to catch criminals because most people follow the laws in society. There is no reason to monitor law-abiding citizens.

Position 3

Surveillance cameras should be used in certain situations where there is a high risk of criminal activity or violence, for example, in banks, prisons, and sporting events with a history of violence. They shouldn't be used for average people who are not likely to break the law.

Vocabulary big brother: A person or organization who has control over the lives of others. Often refers to the government.

public health emergency: A serious but temporary situation where lots of people are in danger from a disease or illness.

criminals: People who commit crimes (stealing, murder, etc.).

criminal activity: Things that people do which are against the law. For example, killing someone, driving while drunk, stealing something from a store, stalking, etc.

violence: Physical force that intends to hurt someone or something.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Should security cameras be used in banks?
4. What about at a shopping mall?
5. Do you generally feel safe when walking around your city? Would more cameras increase the safety level?
6. Should governments know a lot about the private lives of their citizens?
7. What's more important to you: freedom or safety?
8. Should criminals be punished on the basis of surveillance footage?
9. People on the Internet used surveillance footage and photos on social media after the attacks on the US Capitol to identify many of the people involved. Do you think this was right?
10. Most of our phones track our movements. Are you worried about this?

Tattoos and Facial Piercings

Icebreaker Do you have any tattoos or piercings? Please share if you feel comfortable!

The Big Question

Should companies and schools regulate visible tattoos and facial piercings by requiring employees and students to cover them up or remove them?

Position 1

Yes, people should be required to cover up facial piercings and visible tattoos. It's a personal choice to get these things, but it doesn't mean that everyone should have to look at them. It's distracting and can often be a sign of criminal or gang activity, and they make people look unprofessional.

Position 2

Tattoos and piercings are a personal choice and a part of who someone is. No school or company should be allowed to regulate this in a dress code and people should have the freedom to be who they are.

Position 3

Some things shouldn't be regulated. For example, small earrings are non-controversial and nobody is distracted by them. However, a large tongue piercing is distracting and should be removed before going to work or school. Tattoos with gang affiliations should be covered up.

Vocabulary regulated: Controlled in some way.

personal choice: An opinion, quality, or thing that belongs to a person. In this case, the choice to have visible tattoos or piercings at work or school.

dress code: Rules that specify what people can or can't wear at a workplace, school, or event.

non-controversial: Something that everyone accepts and doesn't disagree about.

unprofessional: Not meeting certain standards for how to act or dress in a workplace.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you agree with a little bit?
3. If you were hiring someone for a job, would a tongue or nose piercing impact whether or not you hired them?
4. What about a large tattoo on someone's neck? Would that have an impact on your choice if you were hiring someone?
5. Should people wait until they are legal age (18 or 19 in most countries) before being allowed to get a tattoo?
6. Should tattoo artists refuse to give people certain tattoos? For example, a swastika (nazi symbol) or gang symbols?
7. Do tattoos and piercings sometimes symbolize gang or other criminal activity?
8. Do you think negatively about someone with lots of tattoos?
9. Should companies be allowed to discriminate against someone with lots of visible tattoos when hiring them?
10. Schools have no right to enforce dress codes. Do you agree or disagree?

School Uniforms

Icebreaker Did you have to wear a school uniform when you were growing up? If yes, did you like it? If no, did you wish that you had one?

The Big Question

Should schools require students to wear uniforms?

Position 1

Yes, schools should have uniforms. They ensure equality amongst students and prevent things like bullying and theft. It's easier for students because they don't have to think about what to wear to school each day and can focus on more important things.

Position 2

No, schools shouldn't have uniforms. Students should have the freedom to be themselves and express their personalities. Uniforms can also reinforce gender stereotypes (pants for boys, skirts for girls) and can be harmful to gender non-conforming students. They can also be expensive for low-income families.

Position 3

Schools shouldn't have uniforms, but there should be dress codes to ensure that everyone looks presentable and ready to learn, for example, no ripped jeans, no tank tops, etc.

Vocabulary equality: Equal in rights, status, opportunities, etc.

gender stereotypes: Generalized views of men and women. In this case, that women should wear skirts and that men should wear pants and dress shirts with ties.

gender non-conforming: Describes a person who doesn't fit with the usual gender stereotypes, especially with regard to appearance. For example, a woman who doesn't want to wear a skirt or dress but prefers pants.

low income: Making below a certain amount of money per month or year. It varies from country to country.

bullying: Seeking to harm or intimidate someone.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you agree with a little bit?
3. If schools have uniforms, what should be done about low-income families who may not be able to afford them?
4. If a school has uniforms, boys should be able to wear skirts, and girls should be able to wear pants if they choose. Do you agree?
5. Are there other pros to school uniforms that haven't been mentioned yet?
6. Are there other cons to school uniforms that haven't been mentioned yet?
7. Bullying will happen regardless of school uniforms. Do you agree?
8. School uniforms are helpful for low-income students who may not be able to afford designer clothing. Do you agree?
9. Why do you think children might dislike school uniforms?
10. Do school uniforms help prepare students for work life?

Cheating

Icebreaker Have you ever cheated on a test? Be honest :) Most people have!

The Big Question Is cheating acceptable in order to be successful in school and life?

Position 1

Yes, I think that cheating is okay, and it's actually necessary in order to be successful in life. It's a “victimless crime” and doesn't hurt anyone. In the Internet age, information is everywhere, and you shouldn't have to memorize facts for a test or spend time writing a paper about something if you can just look it up later.

Position 2

No, cheating is wrong in all forms and should be punished harshly. You aren't learning what you should be learning in school if you cheat—you're just getting a passing grade on a test or in a class. You can also get in big trouble if you get caught, particularly in university where you might be expelled.

Position 3

Cheating harms mostly the person who cheats. People should be punished if they get caught, but not too harshly.

Vocabulary victimless crime: Breaking the law in some way but where nobody gets harmed.

harshly: Strongly.

a passing grade: Usually above 50% on an assignment, exam, or course. The requirement might be higher in some cases (60%, for example).

punish: Inflict a penalty on someone.

a paper: In high school or college, it usually refers to an academic essay.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Name a few different situations in which people might cheat.
4. Should people who cheat in college be expelled (kicked out)?
5. Everyone cheats. Does this make it okay?
6. How would you feel if you knew that a classmate cheated on a test, got an A+, but didn't get caught?
7. How can teachers or professors prevent cheating?
8. How do you feel about people who cheat on their taxes?
9. If you had a chance to cheat on taxes to save \$5000 USD, would you do it?
10. What does cheating mean in a romantic relationship?

Censorship and Freedom of Speech

Icebreaker Should people be able to say whatever they want on social media? Why or why not?

The Big Question Should governments and media companies censor what people are able to say in public spaces like YouTube videos or on social media?

Position 1

People who say hateful things shouldn't be allowed to say these kinds of things in public places, like on social media. This is especially true for public figures. They can cause harm to lots of people and incite violence, like with Donald Trump in the United States.

Position 2

In a democracy, people should be allowed to say whatever they want. Freedom of speech is a fundamental right and should always be protected, no matter what people are saying. Everyone has the right to have their own opinion about something.

Position 3

Freedom of speech is important. However, things that are clearly wrong (saying someone “stole” an election when it wasn't the case) should be prohibited on social media. As long as it's true, people should be able to say whatever they want.

Vocabulary freedom of speech: The right to express an opinion without censorship.

incite: Encourage; stir up (in a negative way).

fundamental right: Basic freedoms found in a formal document like a constitution.

prohibited: Not allowed; banned.

public figures: People who are well-known; famous people.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. How does freedom of speech improve society?
4. Should people be free to spread hate about other religions?
5. Should teachers be able to share their personal opinions about things like homosexuality or religion with their students?
6. Do you think your country censors citizens? How?
7. Have you ever had to be careful about what you say? In what situation?
8. How important is freedom of the press?
9. Should public figures be financially or criminally responsible for any harm that results from things they say?
10. Who should censor what's on social media? Nobody, the companies or the government?

Child Labour

Icebreaker How old were you when you had your first job? What was that experience like?

The Big Question Do you think that child labour in all forms is wrong?

Position 1

Children in all countries around the world shouldn't be allowed to work in any form until they're 18 years old. They should be required to attend school and focus on their education instead of earning money. Companies often exploit child and teen workers.

Position 2

No, in some cases, it's fine. Young children can do something like a paper route after school. Or, teenagers can get a job when they're in high school to earn a bit of spending money. They can be valuable members of the labour force for low-skilled jobs. It is wrong if children and teens drop out of school or their grades suffer in order to work.

Position 3

Sometimes children have to work in order to support their families. If the choice is between earning money and eating, or having no food, then the child should work. Ideally, parents would support their children, but this isn't always the case in some countries around the world.

Vocabulary exploit: Take advantage of.

labour force: All the people who are able to work.

low-skilled jobs: A job that doesn't require specific education or experience (anyone can do it).

drop out of: Quit something.

spending money: Pocket money, usually spent on snacks or unimportant things.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Does child labour exist in your country? What is the earliest age someone can legally work?
4. Do you think a lot of child labour happens in family-owned businesses?
5. What should happen to companies that use child labour?
6. Would you buy cheap clothes or electronics produced by child labour?
Or, would you rather pay more for things that are produced by adults?
7. Should teenagers be paid less than adults for doing the same job?
8. Do you think profits are more important than ethics for most companies?
9. Would there be enough people to do the low-skilled jobs in your country if teenagers weren't allowed to work?
10. Do part-time jobs for teens provide them with some valuable experience in the “real world?”

Plastic Surgery

Icebreaker What kinds of plastic surgery are popular where you live?

The Big Question Should people be allowed to get plastic surgery for cosmetic reasons?

Position 1

Yes, people should be free to modify their bodies however they wish. However, taxpayers and national health care systems shouldn't have to pay for it. The people who want plastic surgery should pay out of pocket.

Position 2

Plastic surgery should only be available to people with burns or medical conditions such as a cleft lip. It shouldn't be for cosmetic reasons. If Covid-19 has shown us anything, it's that we need doctors for more important things, not frivolous surgeries!

Position 3

People should be allowed to get plastic surgery if they'd like, and most procedures should be covered by national health programs. Plastic surgery can make people better about themselves, and mental health is important too.

Vocabulary cleft lip: The lip tissues don't completely join together before birth.

out-of-pocket: Paying for something directly, instead of it being covered by the government, insurance, etc.

cosmetic: Involving appearance.

national health program: A health care system that is funded by taxpayers and administered by the government.

modify: Change.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Is plastic surgery popular in your country? For what kinds of things?
4. Would you ever consider getting plastic surgery? Why or why not?
5. Is there a difference between plastic surgery and cosmetic surgery?
6. Why do you think some doctors want to become plastic surgeons?
7. Would you get some cosmetic procedures done if they were free?
8. Should children be allowed to get cosmetic surgery if their parents approve?
9. Should insurance companies or health care systems cover any cosmetic procedures?
10. Have you ever watched any reality TV shows where people get cosmetic surgery? What did you think about it?

Capital Punishment

Icebreaker What does capital punishment mean? Is it legal in your country?

The Big Question Should capital punishment be used for murderers?

Position 1

Yes, murderers should be put to death. Why should they be allowed to live when they've killed someone? It only makes sense, and people will think twice before killing someone if they know that they'll die themselves.

Position 2

Capital punishment is barbaric and cruel. It doesn't stop people from committing crimes, and sometimes the justice system can make mistakes and kill people who aren't actually guilty. However, murderers should spend the rest of their lives in jail.

Position 3

Yes, there should be capital punishment for murderers. Rapists, terrorists, pedophiles, and other people who commit violent crimes should also be included. We don't need those kinds of people in our society. It's expensive to keep these people in jail for the rest of their lives, providing them with free food and medical care.

Vocabulary think twice: Consider something again.

barbaric: Brutal; very cruel.

pedophile: Someone who commits sexual crimes against children.

rapists: Someone who forces a person to have sex with them, against their will.

justice system: The various agencies that administer and enforce laws in a place.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly support?
3. Which crimes should capital punishment be used for (maybe none)?
4. What's the difference between capital punishment and corporal punishment?
5. Do you think that the death penalty can deter people from serious crimes?
6. What do you think of the saying from the Bible, "An eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth?"
7. Do you think capital punishment helps the family of the person who was murdered?
8. Should capital punishment be used for people with mental health issues?
9. Which is worse: capital punishment or the rest of your life in prison?
10. How do you think the doctors and prison officials feel after putting someone to death?

Assisted Suicide

Icebreaker What is assisted suicide (it's also known as medical assistance in dying—MAID)? Is it legal in your country?

The Big Question Should people with terminal illnesses be allowed to use assisted suicide?

Position 1

Yes, people who are terminally ill should be allowed to make use of assisted suicide. It's humane, and if someone wants to die peacefully instead of suffering, they should be able to have that choice. We do it for our pets, so why not for humans as well?

Position 2

It's not for us to decide when our time on Earth should end. Doctors should have no part in facilitating suicide, and it should not be legal. It can lead to all sorts of problems—maybe someone is just depressed and won't feel like they want to die in a few months from now.

Position 3

Assisted suicide should be legal, but it should be very strict for who can make use of it. For example, someone with stage 4 cancer who is older than 70, has gone to counseling to discuss this option for at least 5 sessions, and who has good mental health. They should be free to make use of it, but it's not for the average person.

Vocabulary terminal illness: An illness that doesn't have a cure and will eventually result in death.

humane: With compassion.

facilitating: Helping.

mental health: psychological or emotional well-being.

stage 4 cancer: Advanced cancer that has spread to the organs (liver, kidney, etc.).

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Do you know anyone who has made use of assisted suicide?
4. Why might someone choose to die earlier via assisted suicide?
5. Passive euthanasia is when someone stops taking medication they know will keep them alive. What do you think about this?
6. Should a family member or a doctor turn off the machines that are keeping someone alive?
7. Does religion have any part in this debate?
8. MAID can save on health care costs. It's expensive to keep very sick people alive. What do you think about this?
9. We euthanize our pets when they are very sick. Why is it different for people?
10. Doctors shouldn't cause harm. Most people would agree with this, but where does assisted suicide fit into this?

Gender Roles

Icebreaker Think about your parents. Did they follow certain gender roles when you were growing up?

The Big Question Should men and women act in a certain way and get jobs that fit their gender?

Position 1

Yes, men are better at certain jobs, especially ones that require physical strength. And women are better at certain jobs, particularly ones that involve nurturing. People should act in a way that is appropriate for their gender. This includes how people speak, dress, and act.

Position 2

Men and women should be free to act however they want, no matter their gender. They should also be able to do whatever job they'd like, as long as they are qualified to do it. Gender roles harm trans people in that they make gender binary.

Position 3

People should be able to do whatever job they'd like and dress and act however they want, regardless of their gender. However, it's a fact that some jobs that require significant strength may be better suited to men. And what's so wrong with a woman wanting to wear a dress or a man wanting to appear to be tough and strong? It's not harmful if people have a free choice about it.

Vocabulary trans person (transgender person): Someone who doesn't identify with the gender/sex assigned at birth.

nurturing: Caring.

binary: Involving 2 things.

free choice: The ability to choose.

physical strength: The energy that someone has to move, lift, and carry things.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Do you see yourself as a typical man or woman?
4. Do mothers and fathers in your country have different responsibilities when it comes to raising children?
5. Have you heard of the “glass ceiling?” Is it a problem in your country?
6. Are boys and girls expected to behave differently where you live?
7. Have you heard the phrase, “Boys will be boys?” What does this mean?
8. Are there some jobs that might be dangerous for women? What are they?
9. Is it okay for men to cry?
10. Is there mandatory military service in your country? Is it the same for both men and women?

Gun Control

Icebreaker Are people legally allowed to own guns where you live?

The Big Question Should people be allowed to own guns? Or, should they be restricted to police and the military?

Position 1

Nobody should be allowed to have guns except for the police and the military. They are dangerous and result in a lot of deaths, including accidents.

Position 2

People have the right to defend themselves and their property, and guns are necessary for this. While there should be some restrictions (criminals can't legally buy a gun, for example), they shouldn't be too cumbersome.

Position 3

People should be allowed to have guns for things like hunting and if they live or work in a dangerous environment (with bears, for example). However, nobody except for the police or military needs assault rifles or semi-automatic weapons. These should be severely restricted.

Vocabulary restricted: Limited in some way.

hunting: Killing animals in the wild for fun or to eat.

assault rifle: A rapid-fire gun used in the military.

semi-automatic weapons: A gun that automatically reloads after a shot, instead of having to do it manually.

severely: Strictly; harshly.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Have you ever shot a gun? When?
4. Guns don't kill people. People do. What do you think about this?
5. Is there a solution to all the school shootings in the USA?
6. In Switzerland and Canada, many people have guns. However, deaths using guns are very low compared to the USA. Why do you think this is the case?
7. What checks should be done before someone can buy a gun?
8. If people aren't allowed to have guns, how else can they defend themselves or their property?
9. Do violent movies or video games encourage the use of guns?
10. How do you feel about keeping guns in a house with children living there?

Junk Food in Schools

Icebreaker Are you a “junk food junkie?”

The Big Question

Should schools be allowed to have junk food in vending machines, provide it at special events, and sell it in the cafeteria?

Position 1

Yes, it's a free world! Just because schools have junk food available, it doesn't mean everyone will eat it. It's up to the children and their parents whether or not someone eats it. If parents don't want children to eat junk food, they shouldn't send them to school with money.

Position 2

No, schools have a responsibility to help children and teens make healthy choices at school, and this involves limiting junk food. Students should have access only to healthy choices for snacks, at lunch, and for events.

Position 3

Junk food shouldn't be available to students on a regular basis. For example, it shouldn't be found in vending machines or at the cafeteria. However, it's fine to have some junk food once in a while for a special event, for example, a pizza day or a concession at a sports event.

Vocabulary

vending machine: A small machine that sells candy, pop, snacks, etc.

cafeteria: A kind of restaurant at a school or workplace.

a free world: Used when someone wants to emphasize that people are able to make their own choices and not be controlled.

healthy choices: Not junk food. Fruit, vegetables, lean meats, whole grains, etc.

a regular basis: Regularly; happens at least somewhat frequently.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you somewhat agree with?
3. How do you define “junk food?”
4. What was your experience growing up? Was there junk food at school?
5. Do children bring lunches from home, or is there a cafeteria at school in your country? What do you think about this?
6. Is there a cafeteria where you work? What kind of food do they serve?
7. Do schools have a responsibility to provide children with healthy food? Or, is this a concern only for parents?
8. Do fast food restaurants market to children? How do they do this?
9. Is it reasonable to expect that kids won't eat junk food at school if it's there?
10. Why do you think some people make terrible food choices?

Video Game Violence

Icebreaker Have you ever played a video game that involves shooting or killing people?

The Big Question Do video games cause violence in society? Should they be banned?

Position 1

The increase in things like school shootings can be directly attributed to video games, where violence is realistic and glorified. Therefore, they should be banned, at least for a period of time (5-10 years) to see if gun violence decreases.

Position 2

Things like school shootings happen for a variety of reasons, not just violent video games. The cause is most likely bad parenting. It's up to parents to monitor video game usage among children and teens, and they should be freely available.

Position 3

Video games that involve shooting do perhaps cause an increase in school shootings. However, there are probably other reasons as well (poor parenting, lack of gun control, and ineffective mental health care). Banning video games will only increase their demand and have no effect because people will be able to find them online easily.

Vocabulary banned: Not allowed.

attributed to: Caused by something.

glorified: Representing something in a way that makes it appear special or over-the-top.

mental health care: Treatment of mental illness like depression, anxiety, etc.

demand: How much people want a certain thing.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What does “first person shooter” mean with regards to video games?
4. Should children be allowed to play video games? If yes, what kinds of games?
5. Should video games have a strict rating system like movies?
6. Video games are a waste of time. Do you agree with this?
7. Are there any benefits to video games?
8. What are some other causes of violence in society besides video games?
9. Why do you think video games are so addictive?
10. Are video games too realistic these days? Do they allow people to not actually live in the “real world?”

Human Cloning

Icebreaker What is “cloning?” What are some examples of things scientists can clone?

The Big Question Should scientists try to clone humans?

Position 1

No, scientists should not clone humans. This can lead to all sorts of problems like birth defects, premature aging, and a weakening of the gene pool. It's too risky and not well understood yet. There are also a number of ethical concerns.

Position 2

If it's possible to clone humans, then why not do it? People can get a “second chance” at life. There are risks, but there are also risks with any other medical procedure. The technology is getting better, and these problems can be overcome soon.

Position 3

Cloning humans can be useful for certain things. For example, making new organs for transplants should be explored. However, it has too many ethical concerns to replicate an entire person.

Vocabulary birth defect: Structural changes in the body that are first seen at birth. It may be related to how something looks or works.

premature aging: When typical effects of getting older happen too early.

gene pool: The genetic material in a certain species of animal (can apply to humans as well).

ethics: Morale principles; ideas about right and wrong.

organs: Heart, kidney, liver, etc.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some advantages of cloning?
4. What are some of the disadvantages?
5. Should animals, other than humans, be cloned?
6. What do you think about genetically modified food?
7. Who should regulate cloning? The government? Scientists? Someone else?
8. Would you want to have a clone of yourself? Why or why not?
9. Do you think cloning an entire human will ever be done?
10. If you could clone a famous person from the past, who would it be?

Illegal Drugs

Icebreaker Name some legal drugs where you live. Name some illegal ones.

The Big Question

Should all drugs (marijuana, magic mushrooms, ecstasy, etc.) be legalized and regulated by the government?

Position 1

Yes, all drugs that are currently illegal should be legalized and regulated. This can ensure a safer supply, tax dollars for government, and fewer people in jail for non-violent crimes. We already allow alcohol, which is a kind of drug.

Position 2

No, illegal drugs should not be legalized. People caught selling or using them should be penalized heavily. They are bad for our society and legalizing them will just encourage more people to start taking them.

Position 3

Some drugs like cocaine or heroin that have serious health effects should still be illegal. However, things like magic mushrooms or marijuana should be legalized. Many countries, including Canada, have already legalized these kinds of drugs with good results.

Vocabulary legalized: Something that was previously illegal is now illegal. For example, marijuana in Canada was legalized in 2018.

regulated: Controlled.

non-violent crimes: Illegal activity that doesn't cause physical harm. For example, shoplifting, using marijuana, or jaywalking.

penalized: Facing some kind of punishment.

tax dollars: Money that the government collects for programs, education, police, etc.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Which position do you partly agree with?
3. Some people think that alcohol is more dangerous than marijuana. Do you agree or disagree?
4. Will more people use drugs like marijuana if it's legal? What do you think?
5. What's the difference between a “hard drug” and a “soft drug?”
6. Will legalized soft drugs help reduce crime?
7. Some countries execute (put to death) drug dealers and drug smugglers. What do you think about this?
8. Why do you think that people take drugs?
9. Many people are addicted to drugs. What should the government do to help them?
10. At what age should it be legal to buy cigarettes or alcohol?

Minimum Wage

Icebreaker What is the minimum wage in your country? Can someone afford to “live” on that amount if they work 40 hours per week?

The Big Question Should governments set a minimum wage?

Position 1

Yes, we need a minimum wage in order to protect workers. Companies will exploit people if we let them, and a minimum wage is one way to prevent this. It should be high enough in order to be a “living wage.”

Position 2

No, we don't need a minimum wage. The labour market should set it. If someone has the skills that a company wants, they will get a high wage. If someone doesn't have the skills necessary for today's workforce, they should get paid less.

Position 3

In general, the labour force should regulate wages. Skilled workers will get paid more, and less skilled workers will get paid less. However, the government should have a basic minimum wage in order to protect teenage workers, new immigrants, etc. It should be quite low in order to ensure that companies are able to hire people.

Vocabulary exploit: take advantage of.

living wage: A wage that is high enough for an average standard of living in a certain place.

labour market: The availability of jobs and people to do them (supply/demand).

workforce: People working or available for work in particular area or industry.

skilled workers: People with special training, knowledge, and skills for a certain job.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some “minimum-wage jobs” in your country?
4. What was your first job? How much did you get paid? Was that fair?
5. Do you think that a high minimum wage might encourage “under the table” work?
6. Having a high minimum wage will likely result in higher costs for food, services, products, etc. Are you willing to pay more for these things if the workers are paid more?
7. Does having a minimum wage that is very high result in “outsourcing” to other countries?
8. Will people lose jobs if the minimum wage is raised in your country?
9. Does a high minimum wage perhaps discourage small businesses from starting up?
10. Many people are advocating for “living wages.” This is enough money to be able to live without struggling in a certain place. How do you feel about teenagers getting paid this much money?

Abortion

Icebreaker Is abortion legal where you live?

The Big Question Should people be allowed to get abortions if they want to?

Position 1

Yes, people should be freely able to get abortions if they want to (pro-choice). The health of the mother is most important, and she should also be able to choose if she wants to raise a child or not. Women have a right to control their own bodies, and there are already too many people on this Earth. We don't need unwanted children.

Position 2

Abortions should be illegal for any reason (pro-life). Abortion doesn't take into account the rights of the father and the unborn child. There are many people who want to adopt a child, and women should use this option if they don't want to raise a child.

Position 3

Abortion should be legal in specific circumstances such as rape, incest, when the life of the mother is at risk, or for teenage pregnancies. Late-term abortion should also be banned. If someone wants to get an abortion, they should decide earlier in the pregnancy.

Vocabulary pro-choice: Supporting legal abortion.

pro-life: Against legal abortion.

unborn child: A child still inside the mother's womb. He or she hasn't been born yet.

rape/incest: Sexual assault. Rape can refer to anyone. Incest is from a family member.

late-term abortion: An abortion that happens between the 13th and 27th week of pregnancy (roughly). There is no exact definition of what qualifies as “late-term.”

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some reasons that a woman might want to have an abortion?
4. Is abortion a political issue in your country?
5. Who should decide if a woman can get an abortion or not?
6. A ban on abortion encourages dangerous illegal abortions. Do you think this statement is true?
7. Should religious groups have a role in making laws for everyone?
8. At what point is a fertilized egg a “person?”
9. What is the morning after pill? Would you consider this to be an abortion?
10. What rights should the father have if a woman wants to get an abortion?

Plastic Waste

Icebreaker Are there any laws related to “single-use” plastics where you live?

The Big Question

Should single-use plastics such as checkout bags, plastic cutlery, straws, and ring carriers for drinks be banned?

Position 1

Single-use plastics should be banned. They are an environmental disaster, and these days, there are alternatives made from sustainable materials. Many countries have enacted laws regarding single-use plastic and they've been quite easy to implement.

Position 2

Banning single-use plastics will be inconvenient and expensive for businesses to implement. Cutlery and packages made from wood, for example, are more expensive than plastic. It may also harm some businesses that produce plastic goods.

Position 3

Banning single-use plastics isn't going far enough. The government should also ban things like cheap plastic toys, microbeads in cosmetics, and balloons. These are also harmful to the environment.

Vocabulary banned: Not allowed.

sustainable materials: Things that can be used to produce goods and products without running out. Wood, bamboo, hemp, coconut, cotton, and wool are all examples of this (to name only a few).

cutlery: forks, knives, spoons, and chopsticks.

microbeads: A very small piece of material (often plastic) used in things like face wash or laundry detergent.

enacted: Made a law.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Do you know how plastic is made? If you don't, look it up!
4. What are some of the major causes of global warming? Does plastic play a role in this?
5. What are some of the problems with single-use plastic?
6. What are some ways that your life would change if there was a ban on plastic? Would it be more inconvenient?
7. Can't we just recycle plastic? What are the problems with this?
8. Why is plastic in the ocean a big problem?
9. A ban on single-use plastics will hurt businesses. In what ways might this happen?
10. Are there other problems with plastic besides environmental reasons?

Religion in Schools

Icebreaker Think back to your school days. Did religion have any part in it? For example, prayer before meals?

The Big Question

Should religion have any role in schools?

Position 1

Religion is an important part of life and should have a role in schools and workplaces. For example, prayer and religious instruction should be allowed. It can provide a basis for morals and ethics and produce good citizens.

Position 2

No, religion is a personal choice and shouldn't be taught by the state. It's up to parents if they want to include prayer in their children's lives and take them to a Church, synagogue, or a mosque (etc.). There's also the question of which religion should be taught—it can be tricky in a multicultural society. Religious groups shouldn't impose their values on other groups of people who don't have the same beliefs.

Position 3

Religion as an academic subject should be taught in schools. For example, students should be aware of the major world religions and learn some about what the followers believe. However, it shouldn't be too personal and should certainly not include prayer.

Vocabulary

multicultural society: People of different races, religions, backgrounds, and nationalities all living together in one place.

religious instruction: Education in a school that emphasizes the beliefs of a religion.

prayer: A request for help to God (whoever you might believe God to be).

followers: People who believe and support a certain idea. For example, Christians are followers of Jesus.

academic subject: Area of knowledge or study. For example, Physics, History, English, etc.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you support? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly believe?
3. What are some of the positives of including religious instruction in schools?
4. What are some of the negatives?
5. What are some of the major religions of the world? Do you think that they're basically all the same?
6. Does religion solve problems or make more of them?
7. What's your view on religious freedom? Should people be free to practice whatever religion they'd like?
8. An atheist is someone who doesn't believe in God. What do you think about this point of view?
9. Someone who is agnostic believes that we have no way of knowing if God actually exists. What do you think about this?
10. Why do you think religion causes a lot of conflict in our world?

Public Funding for Universities

Icebreaker How much is tuition for university students in your country? Is this too little, too high, or about right?

The Big Question Should universities be publicly funded?

Position 1

Universities should be publicly funded. This means that students should have their tuition fees covered by the government. It's important to have a well-educated workforce. It's also a way to ensure equality between the rich and the poor. Students will stop competing to attend only a handful of elite universities.

Position 2

Universities should receive no public funding. Students should have to pay the full cost of their education and take out student loans, if necessary. They will have higher-paying jobs later to pay back student loans. Schools can raise money for things like scholarships for poor students.

Position 3

Universities should be partly funded. If the total cost to educate a student for a year is \$10,000, the government should pay \$5000 and the student should pay \$5000. Society gets value from well-educated people, but the people themselves do in the form of higher-paying jobs.

Vocabulary publicly funded: The cost is paid by taxpayers/the government.

equality: The state of being equal.

scholarship: Money paid to support someone's education. It doesn't have to be paid back.

student loans: Money borrowed to pay for something related to education.

elite: Exclusive.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you support? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly support?
3. Did you go to university? How did you pay for it?
4. Should parents have to contribute money to a child's education?
5. Does everyone benefit from a well-educated workforce?
6. In Canada and the USA, everyone knows about the “struggling student,” eating cheap, instant noodles and never going out. Do you have a similar image in your country?
7. Do you think that a university education is necessary in order to be successful in life?
8. Does your country have a few elite universities that everyone wants to go to? Or, are they all similar?
9. Are student loans a good option for young people? Why or why not?
10. Do people in your country often want to study abroad? Why?

Smoking

Icebreaker Is it easy to be a “smoker” in your country? Why or why not?

The Big Question

Should smoking be allowed in public places like restaurants, parks, or beaches?

Position 1

No, smoking shouldn't be allowed in shared public places. It should only be allowed in designated smoking areas, and it should be strictly controlled. Smoking is harmful, and we should make it as inconvenient as possible to be a smoker. Smoking bans result in fewer smokers, which is better for society due to the health risks associated with it.

Position 2

Smoking should be allowed in some public places. It should be up to the business or city. If someone doesn't like smoking, they should go to places where it's not allowed. We shouldn't infringe upon people's freedom of choice. Smoking bans also result in less tax revenue for the government, which can be used to fund things like healthcare.

Position 3

Smoking should be allowed in outdoor spaces like parks or beaches. The dangers of secondhand smoke are reduced. However, it should be banned in all indoor spaces.

Vocabulary public places: Somewhere that is open and accessible to all people. For example, a park, library, or beach.

secondhand smoke: Smoke that is inhaled by someone not smoking. For example, if you're in a car with someone smoking, you will be inhaling secondhand smoke.

health risks: The chance that something will harm or affect your health.

freedom of choice: An opportunity that someone has to freely choose between two or more actions.

infringe: Limit or hinder in some way.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you support? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly support?
3. Some countries have very high taxes on cigarettes to discourage smoking. What do you think about this?
4. Do children have the right to grow up without secondhand smoke in their homes?
5. At what age should people be allowed to buy cigarettes?
6. Have you ever been annoyed by someone smoking outdoors? For example, at a park or beach?
7. Smokers have rights too! What do you think about this statement?
8. Why do you think that people start smoking?
9. Smokers often have a lot of health problems like cancer and strokes. Should they have to pay more for health care costs?
10. Why hasn't your government banned cigarettes completely in your country? Is this a good idea?

Vaccines

Icebreaker Have you recently gotten a vaccine? Which one?

The Big Question Should vaccines be mandatory in order to participate in public life? For example, go to school, eat at a restaurant, or work in government jobs?

Position 1

Vaccines help prevent all kinds of illnesses and protect the most vulnerable in our society. They have eradicated serious things like polio, measles, tetanus, and rubella, just to name a few. They should be required in most areas of public life, especially to attend school or work in a job that deals with the public like a police officer, doctor, teacher, etc.

Position 2

Requiring vaccines infringes upon people's freedom of choice and shouldn't be required. The government has no business regulating our bodies. If someone wants to get a vaccine, they can. If someone doesn't want to, they shouldn't have to.

Position 3

Children should be required to get vaccines for certain things in order to attend school. Vaccines for polio, diphtheria, measles, mumps, rubella, etc. have been around for decades, and pretty much everyone considers them to be safe. However, people shouldn't be required to get immunized for newer illnesses like Covid-19.

Vocabulary

the most vulnerable: The people who can most easily be hurt or harmed.

eradicated: Destroyed completely. In this case, the diseases that are no longer seen.

infringes: Violates.

regulating: Controlling.

immunized: Made resistant to a disease. Usually through vaccination.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there a position that you partly agree with?
3. Why are vaccines important?
4. How would life be different without vaccinations?
5. Do you feel nervous about the newer vaccines against Covid-19?
6. Vaccinations prevent many people from dying prematurely. This can lead to overpopulation. What do you think about this?
7. Will new diseases emerge that require new vaccinations?
8. What about the flu vaccine? Do you get one every year?
9. Do you think vaccines have some negative side effects like autism?
10. We are starting to see some diseases that had previously been eradicated due to people not getting their children vaccinated. What can be done about this?

Social Media

Icebreaker How often do you use social media? What do you mainly use it for?

The Big Question

Does social media have a negative impact on people's lives?

Position 1

No, social media is just harmless fun. It's a way to pass the time, and it's great for staying connected to family and friends. What else is there to do when you're on public transportation or waiting in line for something?

Position 2

Social media has a negative impact on people's lives. Cyberbullying is a real problem and can even lead to suicide by those impacted by it. It can increase isolation, anxiety, and depression. The companies purposely make it very addictive. We'd be better off as a society without it.

Position 3

In small doses, social media is fine. It is a nice way to connect with old high school friends, for example. However, in large doses, it can be harmful. Parents should restrict access for children and teenagers.

Vocabulary harmless fun: Entertainment that doesn't hurt anybody.

anxiety and depression: Mental health issues. Anxiety means worrying about things a lot. Depression is feeling sad a lot.

cyberbullying: Using the Internet to harass or intimidate someone.

suicide: Death caused by someone injuring themselves.

isolation: The state of being alone or separated from others.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Do you think you could go one month without social media?
4. What are some of the positive things about social media?
5. What are some of the negative things?
6. Are there any famous cases of cyberbullying in your country?
7. Social media companies make their platforms purposely addictive. Do you agree with this statement?
8. How do you feel when you see pictures on social media of friends or family doing something fun together, but you weren't invited?
9. Do you have any friends that you know only online? Do you consider them to be your real friends?
10. What do you think about “influencers?”

Renewable Energy

Icebreaker What are some sources of renewable energy?

The Big Question Should countries aim for 100% renewable energy by 2030?

Position 1

Countries should aim to use 100% renewable energy by 2030 because global warming is the biggest concern of our time. Fossil fuels are running out and renewable energy can provide inexhaustible energy, stable prices, and decrease dependence on other countries for oil and gas. Countries like Costa Rica have already done this.

Position 2

We still have lots of fossil fuel to extract from the Earth, and forcing companies and people to use renewable energy will be too inconvenient. It will also be quite expensive to switch over from fossil fuels to things like solar power.

Position 3

100% renewable energy might be too ambitious. However, any new power-generating plants should be focused on renewable sources like wind or solar.

Vocabulary global warming: The average temperature of the Earth increasing, year by year.

inexhaustible: Describes something that doesn't run out.

fossil fuels: Oil, gas, coal, etc. These sources of energy are limited and will eventually run out.

extract: Remove.

stable: Describes something that doesn't change.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. How dependent is your country on fossil fuels?
4. Do you think that using 100% renewable energy can stop global warming? Or, are there other major contributors?
5. Do you make an effort to conserve energy in your daily life?
6. Are there any negatives to renewable energy?
7. Is electricity expensive where you live?
8. If electricity were more expensive where you lived, would you use less?
9. Would you consider buying an electric car?
10. What are some easy ways that the average person can reduce their ecological footprint?

Smartphones

Icebreaker Are you addicted to your smartphone?

The Big Question

Should smartphones and tablets be banned in the classroom?

Position 1

Smartphones and tablets should be banned from all classrooms. Banning them can improve academic performance, cut down on screen time which can harm brain development, reduce cyberbullying, and make cheating more difficult.

Position 2

Smartphones are a fact of life these days and should be used in the classroom. There are lots of tools and apps that can help students learn, they allow for collaboration, and it's what students feel comfortable using.

Position 3

Smartphones and tablets should only be used in the classroom for very specific purposes. For example, looking up some information for a project, finding out how to spell something correctly, or taking a poll. Most of the class should be conducted without them. Students are using smartphones after school, at night, and on weekends so don't need to use them at school as well.

Vocabulary academic performance: How students perform across various subjects.

screen time: Time spent using a device like a smartphone, tablet, computer, or TV.

brain development: The changes in the brain that happen from birth to the early 20s.

collaboration: Working with someone to produce something.

conducted: Managed or led.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. In general, what are some of the benefits of smartphones?
4. What are some of the negatives?
5. What's your experience with using a phone or tablet in the classroom?
6. Should parents strictly limit screen time?
7. Do you think that smartphones help or hinder communication between people?
8. If you had kids, would you let them bring a device to school? Why or why not?
9. Will children bully each other, with or without the Internet?
10. Why might banning smartphones and tablets in the classroom improve academic performance?

Contact Sports

Icebreaker

Have you ever played a contact sport like rugby or American football? Do you want to try it one day?

The Big Question

Should contact sports like rugby or American football not be played by children or teenagers?

Position 1

Rugby and football are very dangerous when it comes to concussions and other head injuries, including brain damage. And not to mention other serious injuries like broken bones and torn ligaments. They should only be played by adults.

Position 2

Playing sports like football and rugby is a part of the middle school and high school experience in many countries. It's up to the parents of these children to decide if he or she should play. Parents can monitor their children for things like head injuries.

Position 3

These sports can be played by children and teenagers, but they should only be the non-contact versions until the age of 16 or 18. For example, flag football instead of tackle football. Once children become adults, they can decide for themselves whether or not they want to take the risk of playing a contact sport.

Vocabulary

concussion: A brain injury caused by hitting or bumping the head so that the brain moves back and forth in the skull.

brain damage: An injury to the brain. It may be serious or less serious, and it can be temporary or permanent.

ligaments: A small band of flexible tissue that holds two bones together.

flag football: Non-contact football. People wear a piece of material that hangs from their waist. If someone from the other team grabs it, it's considered to be a "tackle."

tackle football: The kind of football when someone hits or wrestles someone to the ground so that the play stops.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Have you ever watched a contact sport live? Did you worry about the big hits?
4. Have you ever known anyone who suffered a concussion or other brain injury from playing a sport?
5. Do schools have a responsibility to protect students who are playing contact sports? Or is it up to the parents?
6. Would you ever let your child play American football?
7. Why are football and rugby so popular, despite the risks?
8. Most sports have "concussion protocols." Do you think these are followed?
9. Can better helmets help protect football players?
10. What can happen to someone if they keep playing sports after many concussions?

Homeschooling

Icebreaker What is homeschooling? Is it a popular option in your country?

The Big Question

Should parents be allowed to home school their children?

Position 1

Parents should be free to home school their children if they wish in whatever way they'd like. It's an ideal option for children with mental health issues, aspiring athletes, children who live a long distance from schools, and children who are being bullied.

Position 2

Homeschooling is bad for children's social development as they have to give up standard school experiences like field trips, recess time with friends, class parties, etc. Parents are usually not trained educators, so may not be able to assist their children like a teacher would. Local school boards are usually obliged to check on children doing homeschooling, but they may not have enough resources to monitor them effectively.

Position 3

Parents should be able to home school their children, but they must follow the standard curriculum for the public education system. Children should take tests every year to make sure they are meeting the required academic standards, and if they're not, they should have to go back to school.

Vocabulary aspiring athlete: Directing resources, hopes, and ambitions toward becoming good at a sport.

social development: How children learn to build healthy relationships.

field trip: Going outside the school to experience something firsthand.

recess: A break in the school day where children go outside to play.

curriculum: A guide for educators about what to teach throughout a course or year.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some of the advantages of homeschooling?
4. What are some of the disadvantages?
5. Would you have preferred doing the opposite thing growing up (home school or in a regular school)? Why?
6. Why might parents want to home school their children?
7. Children who are home schooled often report being happier as adults. They generally have better academic performance as well. Should the government encourage more parents to try out homeschooling?
8. Should parents who home school their children pay fewer taxes because they're saving the government money?
9. Formal schooling before the age of 10 is bad for children. Do you agree or disagree with this statement?
10. Is online education with a certified teacher a better option than parents homeschooling children?

Learning a Second Language

Icebreaker How many languages do you know? How well?

The Big Question

Should children learn a second language in schools from a young age?

Position 1

All children should learn a second language in school because it enhances listening and memory skills, builds aptitude in abstract thinking, and it can teach children to effectively solve problems. It's ideal in the global economy to have workers who are proficient in more than one language.

Position 2

Children should focus on their first language in schools as learning a second language can be too difficult, and opportunity cost comes into effect. The time spent learning another language is time not spent on reading in the first language, writing, science, or math skills. It also requires hiring teachers who are proficient in the second language.

Position 3

Knowing a second language is a valuable thing and should be taught in schools. However, it should be taught later, perhaps starting at age 10 or 12. The early years should be spent focusing on building language and math skills in the first language.

Vocabulary

abstract thinking: Considering concepts beyond what is observed physically.

global economy: The world's economic system.

proficient: Good or capable at something.

opportunity cost: The loss of a potential gain from something when another alternative is chosen.

language skills: What enables a person to speak or write.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What's the ideal age to start learning a language?
4. What's the most important second language to learn these days? Is it English?
5. What are some of the advantages of being bilingual?
6. What's the best way for young children to learn a second language?
7. What's the best way for adults to learn another language?
8. Are the best language teachers native speakers?
9. Apps and computer programs will reduce the need to know another language. Do you think this is true?
10. Schools don't exist just to produce workers. They exist to produce well-educated people. What do you think about this statement?

Freedom of Speech

Icebreaker What does freedom of speech mean?

The Big Question

Should we be able to say anything we want, at any time?

Position 1

In a democratic society, freedom of speech and expression is necessary. People should be able to share their opinions in person, on social media, on TV, and in newspapers. If people don't want to hear from certain politicians, for example, they should turn off the TV or not follow them on social media.

Position 2

Freedom of speech is a dangerous idea. Not all ideas are right or worth saying. People should be free to have opinions about things as long as they won't harm anyone. We've all seen what happened in the USA with Donald Trump inciting his followers to violence over election results.

Position 3

People should be able to express themselves freely with the exception of fake news and hate speech. These kinds of misinformation can lead to big problems in society as it can escalate into violence, discrimination, or political unrest.

Vocabulary democratic society: A society ruled by the people. Political leaders are elected by citizens.

opinion: A view or judgement, not necessarily based on fact.

hate speech: Abusive or threatening speech based on gender, sexual orientation, race, etc.

fake news: Misleading information presented as news.

misinformation: False information that is intended to trick or deceive people.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Have you seen examples of misinformation on the Internet?
4. What's your first reaction when you hear about an idea that's very different from yours?
5. Is complete freedom of speech really possible? Is this a good thing?
6. Who should decide on what is hate speech or fake news? Social media companies, the government, media companies, or someone else?
7. What are some countries where citizens are free to express their ideas? What are some countries that have a lot of censorship?
8. Can it be a good thing if the government prevents citizens from looking at certain websites? Why or why not?
9. Can too much freedom hurt people?
10. Should social media companies be punished if they allow hate speech on their platforms?

Mandatory Voting

Icebreaker Did you vote in the last national election? Why or why not?

The Big Question

Should all citizens be required to vote or face a punishment of some kind?

Position 1

In a modern democracy, voting should be mandatory for all citizens of legal age. If they don't, there should be a punishment like a fine. It's our most important right as citizens. In many countries, voter turnout is less than 50% which means that elected leaders don't necessarily represent the majority of people.

Position 2

Making voting mandatory may not result in the best candidates getting elected. People who don't want to vote probably won't do any research about the candidates and their views. It can also hurt poor people who may have to work on voting day.

Position 3

Voting shouldn't be mandatory, but jurisdictions should do all they can to encourage people to vote by removing barriers, registering high school students who are close to legal age, allowing online voting, and expanding the number and times of polling stations. There could even be a reward for voting like a small tax break or a gift card for groceries.

Vocabulary

legal age: The age at which you can vote, buy alcohol, drive, etc. Usually 18 or 19 in most countries.

voter turnout: How many eligible voters vote in an election, as a percentage. For example, voter turnout was 34%.

elected leaders: People who win an election and have some sort of job or title. For example, president, senator, etc.

candidate: Someone who wants to be elected in an election.

polling station: A place where people vote in an election.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some reasons that people don't vote?
4. Is voting the most important right we have? Or, is something else more important?
5. How can countries ensure a peaceful transition of power from one elected leader to another?
6. Who should be allowed to vote?
7. Should people vote for judges?
8. How long should terms be for elected leaders? 4 years? 8 years?
Should there be a maximum number of years?
9. Many countries have very peaceful elections, while other countries have ones with a lot of violence. What's the difference between them?
10. Is too much money spent on political campaigns?

Taxes

Icebreaker Are taxes high in your country?

The Big Question

Should citizens pay high taxes in order to support the weaker members of society and things like good education and healthcare systems?

Position 1

Yes, taxes should be high enough to fund an adequate social safety net. We need to look after disabled people and those with mental health issues. Everyone has a right to universal healthcare and a good education through high school.

Position 2

Taxes should be as low as possible to promote economic growth. In a consumer economy, the more money that people have in their pockets, the more they can spend. The more money that companies have, the more they can invest in hiring people and growing. People can work hard to get ahead, and they shouldn't depend on others to provide things like healthcare or a good education for their children.

Position 3

There's a middle ground for taxes. We do need to provide a minimum income for people who are unable to work due to health problems or disabilities, seniors, and children. Everyone should have access to basic healthcare. However, with lower taxes, there is an incentive to work hard because you can keep a lot of that money.

Vocabulary

consumer economy: An economic system that depends on people spending money on goods or services.

disabled people: A condition affecting the body or mind that makes it difficult to do certain things.

economic growth: An increase in the amount of goods and services produced per person.

universal healthcare: All people have access to a full range of health services when they need them. These services are at least partially funded by the government.

get ahead: Become successful, especially when compared to other people. Usually refers to a career.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Should the government pay for health care?
4. Is it easy to avoid paying taxes in your country? What should be done to people or companies who do this?
5. Is it possible for a country to operate without collecting taxes?
6. Should rich people pay a higher percentage in taxes than poor people?
7. What do you think about taxes on things like gasoline, cigarettes, and alcohol?
8. Do you have any say in how tax money is spent or how high the tax rate is?
9. Would you be willing to pay higher taxes if you knew the money was being used to fight climate change?
10. Do you think there will be any changes in the tax system in your country in the future?

Refugees

Icebreaker Do you know anyone who is a refugee?

The Big Question

Should my country allow more refugees?

Position 1

I want my country to stand up for human rights, show compassion for minorities and those from war-torn countries, and welcome as many refugees as possible. We have an aging population with a low birth rate, and bringing in young refugees with kids can help prevent the economic fallout from a shrinking population. Initially, we'll have to support them, but after a few years, they can contribute to society.

Position 2

We shouldn't welcome refugees from the other side of the world. They should stay close to home because when the wars end, their countries will need them to help rebuild society. We have enough problems in our own society with homelessness and overburdened health and education systems. We don't need more people to stretch resources even thinner.

Position 3

We should welcome some refugees. However, we should be selective and welcome only the well-educated ones who speak multiple languages and will be able to do a skilled job in a short amount of time, for example, doctors, tradespeople, and engineers.

Vocabulary

human rights: A right that belongs to every person.

war-torn: A place that is devastated by war.

minorities: People who share an ethnicity, language, or religion that is not the majority.

shrinking population: A decrease in the number of people in a certain place. Often caused by low birth rates or lack of economic opportunity.

skilled job: A job that requires certain training, education, or skills to do it.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Does your country welcome refugees? Is it a political issue?
4. Do refugees have the same rights as citizens?
5. What are some reasons that people might apply for refugee status?
6. What are some problems that refugees bring with them to a new country?
7. What's the difference between a refugee and an immigrant?
8. What do you think about illegal immigrants?
9. If you could talk to someone in a refugee camp, what would you ask them?
10. What support can a country offer to refugees upon arrival?

The Glass Ceiling

Icebreaker What is the glass ceiling? Is it a real thing in your country?

The Big Question Should companies do more to promote women to leadership positions?

Position 1

Just because some biases are subtle, it doesn't mean that they don't exist. Discrimination against women in the corporate world is a real thing. Companies should actively promote women until they achieve an equal number of men and women in top positions. Women can be very capable leaders.

Position 2

Companies should promote the best person for the job. It doesn't matter if that's a man or a woman. If women don't apply for leadership-level positions because they don't have enough skills or confidence, there isn't much that a company can do. It can be difficult for companies with women in top positions because they may take a year off to have a child.

Position 3

It's 2023! The glass ceiling isn't a real thing these days. Most companies have policies in place to prevent discrimination, and they do a good job.

Vocabulary bias: Prejudice in favor of, or against a certain person, thing, or group.

subtle: Clever; not obvious.

discrimination: Unfair treatment based on gender, sexual orientation, religion, etc.

corporate world: Business and industry.

policy: A course of action.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Do you have any personal experience with the glass ceiling?
4. Do men these days face “reverse discrimination?”
5. Do feminists sometimes go too far?
6. What are some examples of policies and practices that result in a glass ceiling?
7. What are some practical things companies can do to develop more female leaders?
8. Do minorities (gay people, immigrants, etc.) also have to deal with the glass ceiling in the corporate world?
9. Are certain jobs better suited to men and vice-versa?
10. What is the “third shift?” Look it up if you don't know. Does this often exist in your country?

Universal Healthcare

Icebreaker Do you have universal healthcare in your country?

The Big Question

Should all citizens have access to good healthcare for free?

Position 1

All citizens should have access to free healthcare. This will prevent people from going bankrupt or experiencing economic hardship if they get sick. People will see a doctor for small problems before they become more serious. It also means mobility in the labour market as people don't have to depend on a job to provide health coverage.

Position 2

Healthcare should be taken care of by private healthcare providers and insurance companies. Publicly funded systems can have long wait times, may not cover rare diseases, and use up a lot of tax dollars which could be better spent elsewhere. Most people are able to get insurance through their jobs anyway.

Position 3

The best option is a user-fee model. People who visit a doctor have to pay a few dollars while the government covers the rest. Same with various treatments. People will think twice about visiting the doctor, which will free up resources for the really sick people. Nobody will go bankrupt if they get sick, although they may have to pay a little bit out of pocket.

Vocabulary

bankrupt: Completely unable to pay bills or debts.

economic hardship: Describes being unable to pay basic living expenses like food or shelter.

mobility: The ability to move.

tax dollars: Money collected by the governments from businesses and citizens.

user-fee: Money paid to gain access to a particular service or facility.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. If you're sick, is it easy to see a doctor in your country?
4. Do people generally like the health care system in your country? What could be better?
5. Having to pay for health care will encourage people not to smoke, eat healthy, and exercise. Do you agree or disagree with this?
6. The rich, because they are able to pay for it, should get better health care. Do you agree with this?
7. Are people with mental health issues well taken care of in your country? Is this important?
8. Should employers be involved in providing health care to employees? What are some potential problems with this?
9. If you could see a doctor a day or two more quickly, how much would you be willing to pay for this?
10. Do “online” doctors have the potential to save healthcare systems a lot of money?

Going Vegan

Icebreaker Do you know any vegans? What do you think about them?

The Big Question

Should people eat vegan most of the time?

Position 1

People should eat vegan most of the time. It can reduce the risk of things like heart attacks, strokes, and cancer. It's much better for the environment, and it avoids the ethical issues associated with killing animals. As long as vegans eat healthy foods and not just vegan junk food, they'll get all the nutrients they need.

Position 2

Vegans may not get all the nutrients they need, so it's healthier to eat a diet that includes animal products. Our bodies are designed to digest a variety of foods, so why should we limit ourselves to just plants? Meat and dairy are delicious and can bring happiness!

Position 3

There are health risks associated with consuming too many animal products. Factory farms often result in a lot of inhumane treatment and they're not great for the environment. However, eating meat is an important part of our evolution and history. A balanced approach is to be plant-based and not strictly vegan.

Vocabulary

ethical issues: A decision or action that creates a moral problem.

nutrients: Something that provides what is necessary for growth.

evolution: The gradual development of something from simple to more complex.

factory farm: A large industrialized farm designed to maximize profit.

plant-based: Describes someone who eats food that mostly comes from plants instead of animals.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Have you ever considered going vegan? Why or why not?
4. What are some advantages to eating fewer animal products? Are there any disadvantages?
5. What is the biggest problem with eating meat, in your opinion (ethical concerns, health, the environment, other)?
6. Albert Einstein once said, "Nothing will benefit human health and increase chances for survival of life on Earth as much as the evolution to a vegetarian diet." What do you think about this?
7. If you want to eat meat, you should have to kill it yourself. What do you think about this?
8. Is it possible to be a "junk food vegan?"
9. Why don't we eat cats and dogs? Aren't they the same as cows or pigs?
10. What about eating baby animals like veal or lamb?

Zoos

Icebreaker When was the last time you visited a zoo? How did you feel about the conditions?

The Big Question

Should zoos be allowed?

Position 1

Zoos should be banned. They are cruel and inhumane to animals, and it's more about entertainment for people than it is about conservation, saving animals from extinction, or education.

Position 2

Zoos should be allowed because they educate people about wild animals, which can lead to more money for conservation efforts. They can save animals from extinction and even have breeding programs to help endangered species recover. Visiting zoos is part of the normal childhood experience, and everybody should get to see wild animals, not just those rich enough to go on a safari, for example.

Position 3

Most zoos, in their current forms, are cruel to animals. They are too small and cause physical and psychological harm. However, zoos that replicate natural habitats with large amounts of space should be allowed.

Vocabulary

inhumane: Cruel; without compassion.

conservation: Protection of a resource. In this case, animals or animal habitats.

extinction: The disappearance of a certain animal species.

breeding program: Attempting to get a plant or animal species to reproduce.

endangered species: An animal that is at risk of extinction.

Let's Talk

1. Is there a position that you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. Would you be willing to pay more to visit a zoo if the cages were much bigger?
4. How do you think animals in zoos must feel?
5. Why do kids love zoos so much?
6. Banning zoos will encourage private citizens to have wild animals. Do you agree or disagree with this?
7. What's the difference between a safari park and a zoo? Is one better than the other?
8. Why might an animal kill or injure a zookeeper?
9. Do zoos actually protect animals from extinction?
10. Why is it difficult to get animals to breed in captivity?

Technology and Our Problems

Icebreaker Has technology solved a problem that you had recently?

The Big Question

Will technology eventually save us from big problems like plastic waste, global warming, disease, and food and water scarcity?

Position 1

Technology has the potential to save us from things like global warming and food scarcity. We are advancing our knowledge exponentially with each passing year. As computers get more and more powerful, machine-learning has the potential to figure out any problem that we might have.

Position 2

Technology can certainly help with more efficient farming practices or making cars that don't run on fossil fuels. However, they can't solve all of our problems. What is really required is human accountability and a willingness to change to a more sustainable way of living.

Position 3

Technology generally causes more harm than good. For example, it's helped people live way longer than they should, which has contributed to a serious overpopulation problem. And while it is convenient to jump on a plane and go anywhere, it's an ecological disaster.

Vocabulary

global warming: The average temperature of the Earth increasing over time.

food scarcity: A shortage of food.

exponentially: Increasing more and more rapidly as time goes on.

machine-learning: A branch of AI that tries to imitate the way people learn things.

sustainable: Can be maintained over a long period of time.

Let's Talk

1. Which position do you agree with? Why?
2. Is there another position that you partly agree with?
3. What are some big problems that technology can solve?
4. What are some big problems that technology probably can't solve?
5. Do advances in things like food production mean that we can waste food and not worry about it?
6. Do machine-learning and artificial intelligence come with risks?
7. Does each new invention come with a problem?
8. How much longer will people be able to survive on Earth?
9. Governments, not people at the individual level, have to do more to make sure our Earth survives. Do you agree or disagree with this?
10. Planes should never have been invented. Do you agree or disagree?

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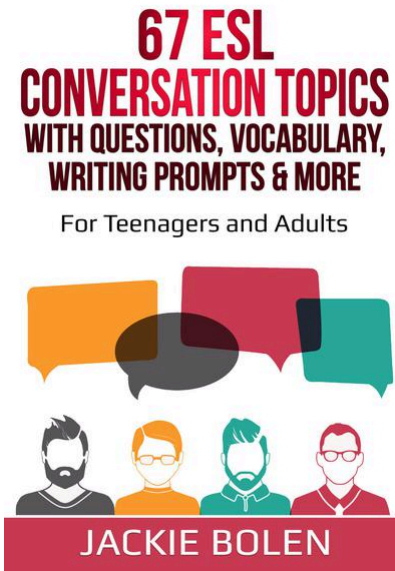
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